This verdant spinach soup is so simple; it takes no more than a few minutes to make, yet sings of the garden. It is beautiful served warm or at room temperature.

spinach and parmesan soup with crème fraîche

SERVES 4 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 15–20 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
BEFORE PARMESAN IS ADDED

10oz (300g) baby spinach leaves
2 tbsp unsalted butter
2 large shallots, finely sliced
1 garlic clove, finely chopped
sea salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 quart (1 liter) chicken stock
5 tbsp crème fraîche
3½oz (100g) Parmesan cheese, grated
grated lemon zest, to garnish

1 Wash the spinach thoroughly, drain, and shake until almost dry. Place a large pan over medium heat. Add the spinach, cover, and cook until it just wilts. Drain in a colander and set aside.

2 Rinse and dry the saucepan. Add the butter to the pan and melt over low heat, then add the shallots and sweat for five minutes, or until softened and translucent. Add the garlic and cook for 1–2 minutes, then season with a little salt and some pepper.

3 Add the cooked spinach and stir once or twice. Pour in the stock and turn up the heat. Bring to a simmer then immediately remove from the heat. Purée the soup in a blender until smooth. Return it to the saucepan and stir in the crème fraîche. Add the grated Parmesan cheese and check the seasoning. Then either reheat gently and serve warm, or allow to cool and enjoy at room temperature. Add a sprinkling of grated lemon zest before serving.